Chapter 1

Understanding Health and Wellness

1. Your Total Health
2. What Affects Your Health?
3. Health Risks and Your Behavior
4. Promoting Health and Wellness

Lesson 1 — Your Total Health

What Is Health?

Health isn't just about your body — it's a combination of many different areas of well-being that all work together. Think of it less like a triangle and more like a web — when one area is struggling, the others feel it too.

The Many Dimensions of Health

- **Physical** — How well your body functions day to day. Sleep 8–10 hours, eat well, move 60+ min a day, skip tobacco and drugs.
- **Mental** — How you think and process the world — ability to learn, decide, and handle challenges.
- **Emotional** — How you recognize, express, and manage your feelings. Bouncing back from setbacks.
- **Social** — How you connect with others. Real, supportive relationships built on respect and trust.
- **Spiritual** — A deep sense of meaning, purpose, and values — feeling your life matters.
- **Financial** — Managing money in a way that reduces stress — one of the biggest hidden drivers of poor health.
- **Environmental** — The health of the spaces around you — clean air, safe neighborhood, access to green spaces.
- **Cultural** — Connection to your cultural identity, traditions, and community.

When these areas are in balance, you experience true **wellness** — functioning at your best. Neglect one area too long and it starts pulling the others down.

The Health Continuum

Think of your health like a sliding scale — from premature death on one end to feeling your absolute best on the other. Every choice moves you one direction. Many Americans drift lower due to **chronic diseases** — conditions like heart disease, obesity, and cancer — most of which are preventable with better daily habits.

Lesson 2 — What Affects Your Health?

Lots of things shape your health that you may not even think about:

- **Heredity** — Traits passed biologically from your parents. You can't change your genes, but you can change how you respond to them.
- **Environment** — Your surroundings — from air quality to access to doctors. Family, friends, and peers influence your choices too.
- **Culture** — Beliefs, customs, and behaviors of your group shape everything from food to spiritual practices.
- **Attitude** — Optimists tend to actually be healthier. A positive mindset is a real health move.
- **Media & Technology** — Constantly pushes ideas about health and lifestyle — not all of it accurate. Stick to .gov or .edu sites and trusted organizations like the CDC.

> Bottom line: You can't control everything, but understanding these influences helps you make smarter choices.

Lesson 3 — Health Risks and Your Behavior

The CDC's 6 Top Risk Behaviors for People Under 24

1. Tobacco use
2. Poor eating habits
3. Not enough physical activity
4. Alcohol and drug use
5. Risky sexual behavior
6. Violence and unintentional injuries

Risk behaviors can threaten your health or the health of others. They build through **cumulative risks** — the more you stack, the worse the consequences. Speeding is risky. Texting while speeding

is way more dangerous.

How to Protect Yourself

- **Prevention** — Regular checkups, wearing a seatbelt, using sunscreen — steps to keep health problems from happening or getting worse.
- **Abstinence** — A deliberate decision to avoid high-risk behaviors including tobacco, alcohol, drugs, and sexual activity that could harm you.
- **Lifestyle Factors** — Everyday personal habits that shape long-term health. Sleep, nutrition, physical activity, and avoiding substances all make a real difference over time.

Lesson 4 — Promoting Health and Wellness

The U.S. spends more per person on health care than any other country — and a huge chunk of that cost could be avoided if more people had solid **health education**: accurate information and the skills to act on it.

Healthy People 2030

Healthy People 2030 sets national health goals every decade. Key priorities: help all Americans live healthier, longer lives and close **health disparities** — gaps in health outcomes across groups based on race, gender, income, location, or disability. Everyone deserves a fair shot at good health.

Health Literacy

Health literacy — your ability to find, understand, and use health information — matters more than age, income, or education level when it comes to your overall health.

- ✓ Thinks critically before believing health claims
- ✓ Knows how to find reliable sources
- ✓ Makes decisions good for themselves AND their community
- ✓ Can communicate health information clearly to others

> The goal of this course is to help you become exactly that — someone who takes charge of their own health with knowledge, confidence, and good judgment.

Chapter Vocabulary

Lesson 1

Health	The combination of many areas of well-being, including physical, mental, emotional, social, spiritual, financial, environmental, and cultural health
Spiritual health	A deep-seated sense of meaning and purpose in life
Wellness	An overall state of well-being or total health
Chronic disease	An ongoing condition or illness such as heart disease, obesity, or cancer

Lesson 2

Heredity	All the traits biologically passed on to you from your parents
Environment	The sum of your surroundings, including physical places and the people in your world
Peers	People of the same age who share similar interests
Culture	The collective beliefs, customs, and behaviors of a group
Media	The various methods for communicating information
Technology	The tools and methods used to deliver media content

Lesson 3

Risk behaviors	Actions that can potentially threaten your health or the health of others
Cumulative risks	Related risks that increase in effect with each added risk
Prevention	Taking steps to keep something from happening or getting worse
Abstinence	A deliberate decision to avoid high-risk behaviors
Lifestyle factors	Personal habits or behaviors related to the way a person lives

Lesson 4

Health education	Providing accurate health information and teaching health skills to help people make healthy decisions
Healthy People 2030	A nationwide health promotion and disease prevention plan with goals set for the current decade
Health disparities	Differences in health outcomes among groups based on gender, race, education, disability, or location
Health literacy	A person's capacity to learn about and understand basic health information and use it to promote their own wellness